

Appendix D

Guidelines for Critiquing Papers

Providing useful, constructive criticism on the writing done by others is a demanding task in most cases. Beyond providing the author with useful observations and suggestions, it also helps the person doing the critique to be more analytical toward his or her own writing. A good critique deals with both the general flow and organization of the paper and the details in the paper. A critique's purpose is to be critical (it attempts to find any of the flaws and weaknesses in the paper), but it should be done constructively (it helps the author produce a better paper). You should be tactful in presenting your criticisms, but do not skirt the problems and issues. Induce the author to *think* about and question what he or she has written. Challenge the author when it is appropriate.

A list of questions and specific directions to help you provide more effective critiques is given below.

1. How clear is the overall thought and meaning of the piece? Does it meet the objective? How effectively and efficiently does it do that? Is it written appropriately for the intended audience? Provide the author with your analysis, perspective, and suggestions.

2. Is the *flow* of thought clear? Does it "guide" the reader's thinking and understanding to the point (objective) that the writer meant to achieve? Is the progression of thought such that it is easy to follow? Are the individual points or thoughts connected and in the most effective order? Provide suggestions to the writer on how to improve it.

3. How well is the written paper organized? Does it use headings, sub-headings, and other manuscript divisions well? If not, can you suggest ways to improve it?

4. Are there ambiguous, normative, or confusing words used that convey the wrong impression or that may not make the writer's meaning as clear as possible? Are all words and phrases technically correct? Offer suggestions as well as criticisms.

5. Cover both the general and specific aspects of the paper, but concentrate on the general considerations (e.g., overall organization and flow of thought) first, then deal with the details (e.g., specific wording, grammar, etc.).

6. Help the writer with corrections and suggestions on straight editorial matters (spelling, punctuation, sentence structure, etc.). However, it is not your function to “clean up” someone else’s poor writing. If someone asks you to review a paper, they owe you the courtesy of making sure that the mundane matters have received sufficient attention to make good use of your valuable time. If they have not done so, they do not deserve a helpful, or even courteous, response from you.

The above guidelines and suggestions apply to papers in general. For additional perspective specific to reviewing and critiquing for economics journals, see Hamermesh (1992, pp. 176–179).